

— A FIELD GUIDE —



MASTERING THE GAME OF ALLYSHIP

STUCKNESS IS DATA, NOT FAILURE.

— WENDELL BRITT —

THE INFINITE ARCADE

What You Spend, and What Comes Back

The Game You Didn't Know You Were Playing

This book is three years late.

I made a promise to readers who trusted me with their money and their hope, and then I couldn't deliver. The reason, when I finally let myself look at it clearly, was both embarrassing and fitting: I was writing a book about allyship, and it was making me feel like a worse ally. Not to the people I was trying to serve. To myself, to the people closest to me, to the work itself.

I knew that helping people from a place of scarcity doesn't work. I'd built a whole framework around that idea. So I told myself I wasn't doing that. I was being responsible. I was staying in integrity. Every word of that was true, and every word of it left the guilt nowhere to go. It went underground. The work went with it.

It wasn't until I gave myself permission to actually be mad (at myself, about the delay, about the gap between who I said I was and what I was doing) that I saw what was happening. I was holding myself hostage. Because I couldn't be perfect in the way I'd decided I had to be, I ended up doing the exact opposite of what I set out to do: making the work smaller, slower, less alive. Less fun.

Seeing the pattern is what let me finish. It didn't have to disappear first. I kept playing, and the charge that came off looking at it is what I alchemized into the book you are holding.

You're the person I made that promise to.

Your allyship has been run by a part of you that you have never met. In the second where a harm gets named out loud or slides past, that part decides, and it decides before the conscious you arrives. It works from inherited reflexes, old wounds, and the face you reach for without checking whether it fits. It plays by one rule, and the rule is keep you safe. Helping the people you meant to serve was never its assignment. What changes now: you take the seat. This whole book builds toward that move, and that is why so much of it runs on shadow work. Your shadow is the game master. You cannot take the controls from a player you refuse to look at.

. . .

You do not need to be perfect to begin. You only need to be willing to play.

You walk into a meeting or a dinner or a group chat and you catch something nobody else seems to catch: a game already running under the surface. Somebody gets talked over, or a decision lands on the person with the least power to absorb it, and the temperature drops while everyone keeps talking. You are the one who moves, changing who you look at and slowing the conversation down and saying the sentence that costs you something, even though nobody handed you that job. That pull, to step into a game no one invited you to play because you can see it and cannot leave it alone, is the call. You have been answering it since before you had a word for it.

Underneath it runs a feeling you have never fully worked through. It sits closest to worry, the low and steady kind that never switches all the way off. You can see how the systems you were born into wear people down by design, and you can see how little your moves seem to move the machine, and you keep playing anyway while the worry keeps running underneath the play.

Most calls to allyship arrive like a summons to court: formal, accusatory, and already halfway to sentencing. You are either with us or against us. You are either listening, learning, amplifying, or you are complicit. The game, they say, has already started. You're just late to the rules.

The summons is the beginner's game. Somebody built it to run on compliance, and it collects plenty, and the people it was supposed to help are still standing where they were.

More trying is not the answer. The evolved version (the relational, emotionally literate, I've-done-my-work version) arrives at the same wall the beginner's does, because a debt sits underneath them both: a wrong to restore, an effort that finally offsets the damage. Most of the stories you tell about your allyship end with you falling short. The effort was real. It went into retiring a debt designed never to clear, and some part of you has started to wonder whether the game itself is the problem.

Christina Maslach mapped burnout in three dimensions: exhaustion, the depersonalization that distances you from the people you serve, and the loss of any sense that your effort matters. Paul Gorski's work on activist burnout adds the mechanism that makes ours specific: when your activism fuses with your identity, you have no way to regulate the cost. When the work is who you are, no mechanism lets you say "I've spent enough today." The selflessness everyone praises is the same mechanism that empties you out.

Turn that instrument around. Exhaustion, the depersonalization that puts distance between a person and everyone near them, and the loss of any sense that it matters describe the person you came to help at least as well as they describe you. The Trevor Project finds that trans and nonbinary young people whose pronouns most people in their lives get right attempt suicide at about half the rate of those who do not, and that fewer than half of them get that.

The same three numbers come back from either chair. So a move that lands wrong does not only cost you. It spends theirs as well, and meaning well does not reduce the bill. That is what the burnout story leaves out when only your side tells it.

The debt frame is the identity fusion made conscious: it's the story that justifies why you can't stop. You owe something you inherited rather than chose. Unlike a financial debt, this one has no final payment, no moment when someone hands you a receipt. The debt was always designed to stay unpayable. Recognizing that is accurate accounting.

The game frame is the medicine for this, and it works because a game does something specific to your relationship with the stakes. It puts distance between you and the outcome. That distance is detachment, the healthy kind: it lets you stay in a charged fight without the charge running you. You are playing this game. You are not the game. The player fused with the outcome can't play well. The player fused with the cause can't serve it for long.

Using the game frame also clears away most of the uncertainty that plagues people who want to be allies. A game gives you a set of rules. Once you've learned them, you no longer have to think about how to play, even while you're still figuring out how to win.

The people you've been most loyal to in this work already knew the vocabulary. You built it together. You assembled the frameworks in the college friend group, piece by piece, over years of conversations that felt like the most important conversations you'd ever had. You carried them into the progressive org spaces, where the right term signals safety before you've done anything to prove it. You still use them in the dating profile and the group chat, where fluency in the language is the price of admission, and everyone pays it because the alternative is to start from scratch every time.

I have spent my whole adult life in those spaces, and I have needed them. The shared language does something good: it gives me permission to lower my guard and show up as myself. The same fluency that lets me in keeps other people out. It can also pass for the work itself. Speaking the language starts to feel like helping the people I am trying to serve, when all it has done is get me through the door. That is a game of its own, and it is one I have played for myself. The move looks like allyship. The payout lands in my safety and my belonging, and the person I meant to serve never sees a penny of it.

Real allyship happens in plenty of places that game never reaches, and there, fluency earns you nothing. Children receive care or not based on whether you actually understand what they need, and your theory of harm is invisible to them either way. People from cultural traditions different enough from yours meet the language of allyship as an import, one more Western frame explaining their experience back to them. Community organizations

do unglamorous, necessary work in a register with no political language at all, where nobody has ever said “center the marginalized” out loud and people are being fed. Most of the examples ahead happen at work, and several assume you have a budget or a say in how the work gets scheduled. An office leaves its machinery where you can see it, and I have spent my hours there. If your hardest hour this week happens at a kitchen table or in a queue, and nobody has ever asked your opinion about the rota, the move is the same. The furniture is yours to change.

You have watched this happen up close. In the summer of 2020, people who had never organized anything showed up ready to help, and some of the spaces they walked into asked them to master a vocabulary and a set of positions before they could hand out a meal or knock on a door. The impulse was earned. Newcomers with good intentions do real damage, and the language was a way to screen for care. Over time, though, the screening became the event. Getting the words right started to count as the help itself, and people who were ready to do the work heard that they had to speak correctly first. A good number of them left.

This is an old pattern wearing new clothes. Missionaries once required the people they came to serve to convert before they would hand out the food, and most of us recognize that now as a betrayal of the help itself. Fewer of us are willing to ask whether the vocabulary we have built asks for the same conversion, less visibly: a set of conditions to meet before the real help arrives. Sometimes the vocabulary is necessary. We almost never stop to assess whether it is.

The game you moved into has the same design flaw, and I want to be careful here because I ran it for years. The suffering that actually moves you is enormous and far away, and you cannot reach it. Helplessness like that does not resolve on its own. Left unmetabolized, it turns into a drive to protect you from what it can, including the people nearest to you. Just because they are close enough to touch doesn’t mean they are a threat. The friends who vote the wrong way, the parents and their casually racist comments, the coworker constantly transacting in microaggressions: trying to fix these people will be a painful lesson in learned helplessness. You set out to raise

their consciousness the way Pygmalion set out to carve himself the perfect woman, and converting them starts to feel like doing something about the suffering you cannot reach. The words make a very convincing receipt. You said it correctly, so surely you are helping.

The ones who will not let you carve them become your enemy. If they are not with you, they are the problem you are fighting, and that fight eats the hours and the care you could have spent on someone who actually needed you. You pour everything into converting the people around you to your vision of the good, and I mean everything. Then one of them pushes back, and you hit the wall you cannot step around: you might have hurt someone by trying to help them, and you might never have asked whether they wanted your help in the first place.

That shock exposes the conflict the whole game is built on, and it is not a flattering one. Everything that makes you feel like a good person depends on other people needing your help. The role of the good ally only pays out while someone is still broken enough to need saving, which means some well-hidden part of you has a stake in the problem never fully resolving. I know how that reads. It was true about me, and I had the framework that was supposed to prevent it. Your service runs on their need. The payouts are real and specific: the friends who love you for your fluency, your standing at work as the conscientious one, the small private certainty that you are one of the good ones. The game hands you every bit of it, and it stops paying the day you admit the game does not work. Walk away and you lose the things that told you who you were. Stay and you keep doing work you already know does not help.

Before you read on, one instruction. (Yes, already. You just walked in and I'm handing you homework. Stay with me.)

You came here to get better at this, and "this" will not hold still. Every year brings a new community to understand, a new history to catch up on, a new set of words to get right, and I promise you one more will emerge before you reach the last chapter. So you have been trying to study all of it at once, to be fluent in everyone, to never once be the person who gets it wrong. I know

this move intimately. I wrote a whole book about not doing this move, and I did it the entire time I was writing.

Here is the good news, and it happens to be the whole design of the book: you do not have to learn everyone. You learn one process, and you run it on one person, or one community, or one cause, all the way to the end. Then you shuffle up and run it again on the next one. That replay is on purpose. It is the difference between a book you finish and a game you keep coming back to. You did not burn out from caring too much. You burned out from starting the process on everyone and finishing it with no one.

So pick one: the community you keep trying to help from the cheap seats, the cause that has been billing you for years, or the person whose fight you want to stand next to without turning it into a documentary about your growth. Choose the one where you care the most and change the least (you already know which one it is), and bring it with you into every chapter. You do not have to fix it today. You just have to keep it where you can see it. This is where you pick up the joystick.

THE MYTHS THAT KEEP YOU PLAYING THE WRONG GAME

Most people arrive at allyship carrying a wish and a set of questions. The wish comes from something wrong that will not leave them alone: wanting to be someone who does something about it. Nobody says the questions out loud. Am I good enough? Do I matter? Do I belong here? If I get this wrong, do I get cast out?

You answered those questions with myths, the way everyone does. Myths are how human beings make sense of a world too big to hold; they give reality a shape you can move around in. Here is what the guilt never tells you: every one of these myths is a solvable puzzle, and this book hands you the moves to take each one apart. Just seeing the whole map of them, before you solve a single one, makes you a sharper ally than you were a page ago.

Allyship looks like the honorable place to bring those questions, and springs the trap. Bring them here and the question flips underneath you: instead of asking whether you are good, you start trying to prove it, one act of help at a time. That is the master myth, allyship means being good, and

it comes in ten versions. A few of them are almost certainly running you right now.

- Allyship means being good.
- Allyship means helping the less powerful.
- Allyship means fixing the problem.
- Allyship means sacrificing yourself.
- Allyship means paying down what you owe.
- Allyship means being seen doing it.
- Allyship means saying the right words.
- Allyship means following the right people.
- Allyship means never causing harm.
- Allyship means having the right framework.

(The Myths Read, a short and unflattering diagnostic at masteringlyship.com, marks which of these are yours and takes each one apart. It scores how you actually behave, and it has no score for which kind of ally you are, because that question belongs to the trap.)

Every one of them holds a little truth, and that truth keeps them alive. Goodness matters, language matters, repair matters. The damage starts when one of them becomes the whole definition. The day allyship means being good, every exchange turns into a test you are taking, and the person in front of you stops being a person and becomes the examiner. You stop watching them and start watching yourself for proof that you passed. The help never lands, because you were looking at the scoreboard in your own head the whole time. You spend everything, they receive almost nothing, and you go home wondering why caring this much leaves you this empty. That emptiness is the receipt for a game that was never built to be won. It was built to keep you playing.

I know that game from the inside. For three years I helped people in order to prove I was good, and I spent every one of them writing the book that tells you not to.

It broke the day someone I had been “helping” told me, plainly, that my help had been about me the whole time. I wanted to argue. I could not. The

scoreboard went dark, and behind it sat a question I had never asked: what if being good was never the game?

Here is the definition this book is built on.

Allyship is the practice of increasing another person's well-being while protecting the conditions that allow both of you to remain full players in the game.

Nothing in it asks whether you are good. The moment my help requires me to disappear, or turns you into a project or proof that I am good, we have left allyship. The definition guards the conditions where both of us can keep making real moves.

So you are not the defendant waiting on a verdict about your character. You are a player who has spent years inside a game someone else built. The myths are its rules, handed to you by people you trusted or absorbed so early you never saw them arrive, and you have been straining to win something that was rigged before you sat down. You can look straight at it, decide it is not yours, and stand up. Once you are on your feet, you get to build a different game, with rules you would actually choose. That is what the rest of this book is for.

THE TOKEN SYSTEM — WHAT YOU'RE SPENDING

You pay attention to play any game, and in an arcade you pay a currency on top of it. The first rule you get to rewrite is what you pay with.

In the Arcade the currency is tokens, and they come in two kinds. Most of us have only ever been handed the first. **Non-renewable tokens** come from scarcity: guilt, obligation, the need to be seen as good, the inherited debt you keep trying to retire. They are accelerant. They move you right now and bill you later, and the bill comes due in feeling worse about yourself, so every drop you burn has to be paid for by burning a little more of you. This is the fuel most allyship runs on. Show up, amplify, center, listen, do more: none of it wrong, all of it silent about the fact that you have been feeding the game your own body. (Yu-kai Chou spent a decade mapping exactly this: why some fuel keeps a player in the game and some burns them out of it.)

Here is the myth this section takes apart. You have believed that the emptier you get, the more the care must have counted. Depletion looked like the proof that devotion leaves behind. It is a design flaw. You have been using yourself as the fuel, and a fire that eats its own hearth goes out.

The second kind is renewable tokens. They come from the satisfied states you reach by metabolizing a feeling all the way through, the ones you will meet by name in Chapter 3. They cost something too, and they hand back more than you spent. Nobody leaves them lying around to be collected. You make them.

Remember the anger I told you about, the anger I finally let myself feel? Here is the machine underneath that moment. For three years I fueled this book with guilt, and guilt is that first kind: it got me to the desk and left me stranded there, emptier every month, until I was sitting in front of a chapter I could not write with no way to tell tired from done. The whole time there was a full tank I would not touch, the anger at the delay and at myself and at the gap between who I said I was and what I was doing, because a good ally stays in integrity and does not get mad. The day I stopped swallowing it and actually burned it, it did not drain me. It moved me. The book got written on the fuel I had been treating as contraband.

That conversion has a name: Emotional Alchemy, the engine under the whole book. It takes the charge you are most afraid to spend (the fear, the anger, the sadness most people are trained to keep down) and turns it into fuel that returns. What you can carry off this page is smaller and immediate: the charge that rises in a hard moment is ore, and you have been spending it as pure loss. The question stops being *can I afford to feel this?*, and becomes *what is this, and can I burn it clean?*

You do not have to become the mint today. The move is smaller: stop believing you are only ever the battery. You are not a fixed supply being drawn down to nothing. You are someone who can make more of the fuel the game runs on. What it earns you back, once you start spending it well, is the next move on the floor.

THE TICKET SYSTEM — WHAT YOU'RE EARNING

Spend tokens in a real arcade and the machine, if you play well, spits out a run of tickets. You carry them to the counter in a sweaty fistful and trade them for a prize. That is the half of the economy the Token System left uncovered: what the playing pays back.

Allyship has a prize counter too, and most people have spent their whole lives feeding tickets into the wrong one. The counter marked applause pays out in being seen as good, in the right people nodding, in the post that does numbers. Those look like winnings. They are external, they vanish the moment the crowd turns, and you already know what they are worth: you perform the care, you feel like somebody for an hour, and you are empty by dinner. (I know that counter. I wrote whole chapters of this book standing at it and had to throw them out, because you can hear it in the prose, the hollow ring of a man collecting tickets instead of playing.)

The other counter pays out a prize nobody can take back: a felt sense of satisfaction that only shows up when you actually played. You said out loud, in the meeting, that the decision was landing on the person with the least power to absorb it. You stayed in the hard part of the conversation instead of smoothing it flat. You went back to somebody you got it wrong with and said so. You walk out tired, and the satisfaction is still there at dinner. Chapter 3 is where you learn to make it on purpose.

In a real arcade the prize is a dead end: you win the bear, the bear sits on a shelf, the game ends. The allyship Arcade runs the other way, and the prize converts back into tokens. The satisfaction you earn from playing well is renewable fuel, and it goes straight into the tank. This is why the better you play, the more you have to play with. A performance drains the tank and hands you a bear. A practice fills it, and a filled tank is the difference between burning out and getting to play for the rest of your life.

Return to whatever you brought with you. After you engage it, do you walk away with more fuel in the tank or less? That answer is your real score, whatever you looked like earning it.

THE TRUST SYSTEM — WHAT THEY DECIDE

I have been calling the Arcade a floor full of machines, which holds up until the moment allyship starts. The person you came to help is not a machine. They are a player, running a game of their own, and you are the one who walked onto their floor.

Some machines on that floor have a bouncer in front of them, and there is nothing human about it. Built long before you showed up, running on its own, answering to nobody, with one job written into it: keep everyone away from the player it guards until the newcomer proves harmless.

The bouncers are there for a reason. Some of the people who hurt this person arrived offering help, and a bouncer that has met one of those keeps the shape. It does not weigh you up, and it does not wonder about you. It checks you against the shape, before anybody has said much, and it checks fast.

Behind the bouncer, the person is working out three questions about you, and that takes a good deal longer than the door does. Whether you can actually help. Whether you do what you said you would do. Whether you meant well. Capability, integrity, and benevolence, if you want the words for them. The words are Mayer, Davis, and Schoorman's, and Appendix G says where to read them.

The first two you do. The third you are, and that difference runs the whole economy. Doing leaves a record somebody else can check. You got better at it or you did not. You kept your word or you did not. What you are leaves no record, so they guess.

So you cannot work on the third one directly. You can become a kinder person, and it matters, and it still does not put the finding in their head. A decade of being seen incorrectly is available to anybody who wants one.

I have just handed you a diagram of how trust gets built, and a diagram like that doubles as instructions for faking it. I know, because I have used it that way. Looking capable is cheaper than getting good. Sounding reliable is cheaper than being reliable. The shortcut works, which is the honest problem with it. It just pays nothing. Tricking somebody into believing you are a good person is not a feeling anybody enjoys, including the person doing it.

A door like that changes the question. The useful one is how small a move you can make that still counts. Saying what you noticed, to one person, is about as small as it gets, and almost anybody can receive it. Saying what you noticed to somebody's face, with other people listening, asks for far more, and it needs a history behind it before it lands at all. You will meet that one with the Diplomat in Chapter 7.

Which means some games on this floor stay shut to you for now, however many tokens you brought. You prove yourself first, and not to the person. To whatever is standing in front of them. You will find out who those bouncers are in the next chapter, and you will meet your own first, because you have a set of them too and they are why certain doors never open for you either.

You and the person you came to help are not playing the same game. You walk a floor picking machines, spend what you brought, and leave whenever you like. They are holding lines, drawn long ago by parts of them they have never met. They won't be taking them down no matter how hard you intend to mean well.

Which brings me back to the prize counter. What I collected there for years was praise, and praise has a shape to it. Somebody stands above you and grades you. That is the trade, every time. Take your winnings in praise and you have agreed to be judged by the person handing it over, which puts one of you above the other, and you are now doing something other than allyship.

Encouragement is the smaller word and the better one. *That helped. Thank you. I know where I am now.* Each of those three tells you what happened to the person saying it. None of them says anything about your character. That is the test, and you can run it on anything anybody hands you.

Somebody owns the prize counter.

I collected at the one marked applause for most of my adult life and never once wondered who stocks its shelf, or why every prize on it is the kind you carry home by yourself.

The reason is not a secret. Changing something costs money, and somebody currently holding that money has to give some up: a budget line, a promotion that goes elsewhere, a schedule that stops being convenient.

The post that does numbers costs an afternoon. Where both are on offer the second one gets bought, and the people who would have paid for the first keep what they have. Those are the owners, and keeping that shelf stocked is how they collect.

My fluency was the best luck that arrangement ever had. Every hour I spent getting good at the language was an hour nobody spent asking what had changed, and getting good cost them nothing. I paid for the lessons. They kept the budget line, and I stood at the counter as the standing proof that it pays. Call it the fluency dividend: what an arrangement earns every hour you spend getting better at describing it.

I can teach you to see who is collecting. I can teach you to check what your move bought, who it bought for, and whether the person you meant to serve got any of the payout. Every chapter with a Face in it closes by asking where the work lands, because a move that lands on nobody is one the arrangement gets for free. What I cannot do is get you the owner. I have not worked that out, and anybody who tells you they have is selling you a better place in the same line.

So the move this week is a small one. Go back to what you brought with you and find the person inside it. Work out the smallest move that would actually help. Do that, and let them tell you what it was worth.

WHY A GAME

The opening gave you one reason to run allyship as a game: the frame sets distance between you and the outcome, and it hands you clear rules and objectives in a place where most people are improvising blind. Detachment and clarity are the first reason.

The second reason is the one that makes serious people wave the whole idea away: a game is fun. If “fun” sounds too small for work this heavy, call it by its real name: engaging. A chore needs you to supply the motivation; a game supplies its own. That is the entire difference between the two.

If making allyship a game feels like it cheapens something sacred, look at what the alternative actually costs. Most allyship is built as a chore (a duty, a debt, a weight good people carry), and it runs on the fuel we already named as

the kind that empties you: obligation, guilt, the grim credit of having suffered for the cause. That model fails because caring, run as suffering, burns down to nothing, and the person you showed up for is left standing there the day you finally collapse. Unless you are built to find meaning in your own depletion, a version of this work that offers you no engagement is a version you will quit.

James Carse put the distinction in its cleanest form. A finite game is played to win and it ends. An infinite game is played to keep the play going, and the only way to lose is to stop playing. Allyship has no finish line, which makes it infinite by nature, and nearly everything built to support it is finite: a campaign, a pledge, a training you complete, a bar you clear and then clear again. Burnout is what it feels like to run finite equipment on an infinite road. That is why this chapter is called the Infinite Arcade, and it is why the answer is a better game rather than more willpower.

Chou's decade of mapping answers a second question: what pulls people back to one activity for years and drives them out of another for good. Games are engineered around the first kind of pull. Allyship, almost always, is built out of the second. Calling a game a trick for making serious work go down easier gets it backward. A game is the only structure that generates the energy to keep doing serious work for a lifetime instead of one burnout cycle.

The third is that a game is the only frame that will get you to look straight at the part of your allyship you least want to see, and enjoy it.

Here is what I left out of the story I told you at the start. When I said I held myself hostage for three years, I made it sound like something that happened to me. It wasn't. Some part of me was getting off on it: the martyrdom, the being-behind, the noble suffering of the ally who cares too much to finish. A hidden part of me was feeding on all of it, and that's exactly why I couldn't stop by deciding to. You cannot quit a pattern you don't know you're enjoying.

Carolyn Elliott calls this existential kink: the shadow doesn't run you because it feels bad. It runs you because, somewhere out of sight, it feels *good*, and you've never let yourself admit it. People needing you feels good. So does a line you never have to cross, and so does an exhaustion other people

can see. Some part of you is delighted by exactly what you complain about, and as long as that delight stays in the dark, it owns you.

In a game you turn the lights on. You take the charge you have been running in secret and set it on the board, where you can finally see what you are getting out of it, say so, and (this is the whole move) enjoy it on purpose instead of by accident. The moment the pleasure turns conscious, it stops being your driver and becomes your fuel. Grit your teeth against the pattern and you are doing a chore. Catch yourself in the act, name your own existential kink, grin, and you are playing.

Look at what that hidden delight actually buys you. It buys safety: while you are the one who cares too much and never quite finishes, nothing you might get wrong ever gets attempted. So fear has been sitting at the center of the work, and you have been paying it off instead of feeling it. Fear you fight freezes you or turns you back. Fear you look straight at opens into wonder, the same charge pointed at the door instead of away from it.

Detachment, engagement, and the nerve to look at what you would rather not. Those are the three reasons, and the rest of this book is built on them.

Allyship reaches you as three games running at once: the lucky breaks you cannot schedule, the skills you can actually build, and the love that keeps you coming back. Everything ahead is built to strengthen your hand in all three.

WHICH GAME ARE YOU PLAYING

Somebody found me at an event once to tell me that something I had said had given another person a bad trip. I did not want it to be true. I also could not prove it was not me, because I say a lot of wild stuff. So I went to find them.

The person I found was hours in and frightened. I know how to sit with that. Trip sitting is harm reduction, and harm reduction is allyship whether or not anybody in the space would use the word. I had learned trip sitting a long time before that night, for its own reasons, and I never once thought it would come in handy. We talked for a long time, and they came out the other side.

Afterward the person who had come to find me worked out that it had not been me at all. It had been somebody at that event who looked like me.

Two moments from that night matter here. The first is that I went without saying a word in my own defense. I could not tell you how that looked from outside, because I was not watching for that. I was going to find somebody.

You cannot read allyship off how it looks. The evidence arrives too late. Nobody can see your intention. What people can see is what your move did to somebody, and that lands late, sometimes years late, while the performance lands at once. So the confusion does not fall evenly. Whoever performs well collects before anybody can check, because the counter pays out on the performance and the impact is still on its way.

The second moment came once I was in the doorway. Everything I did in there was skill. I had built it slowly, for reasons that had nothing to do with that night, and it was there when I reached for it. What put me in the doorway was a stranger with my face saying something to somebody, and somebody else getting the two of us confused. If that mix-up had landed on anyone else in the building, the person in trouble would have had nobody.

Two different games were running that night, and I had spent years calling them by one name.

Each of the three pays out differently. Most frameworks teach one and treat the other two as mistakes. The move is to tell them apart, because you play each with a different hand.

Games of Chance — right place, right time.

The coin pusher takes your token, drops it onto a shelf already crowded with everybody else's, and slides a bar forward. Most drops move nothing. Then one you played exactly like the last forty sends a sheet of tokens over the edge. You cannot aim it. You feed it steadily and it pays in bursts you did not earn, which is why the biggest single payouts on the floor come off machines like that, and why nobody can tell you when.

Allyship has that machine. It is the reorg that dissolves the case your coworker spent two weeks building, the week before she files: timing you never touched, three floors up, deciding everything. It runs the other way too. You are on a group thread you got copied on by habit, you catch that the panel is about to hire the wrong person, and the one message you send, because you happened to be there to send it, lands the right person the job.

Chance earns a category to itself because standing there is the whole move. Keep showing up where the break could land, and refuse to read the stretches that pay nothing as failure. When the reorg eats the case you did not misplay it. You were in the game, which is all Chance ever rewards.

Games of Skill — the part you can build.

Skeeball measures you. You roll, the machine reads where the ball landed, and tickets come out of the slot in proportion to how well you rolled. Nobody has ever hit a jackpot on skeeball. You get back what you earned, every time, which is the whole appeal and the whole limit.

Allyship has that machine too. Hearing what a person means underneath what they say is a skill. Naming your walk-away price and saying it before the pressure says it for you is a skill. Nobody is born fluent; you get these the way you get any of them, doing it badly and then less badly.

Skill earns one because it improves, and because you can carry it somewhere else. With one catch: a skill pays only where somebody wants it. Bring the sharpest skeeball game in the world to an arcade whose owner is exhausted and going under and you will not make a dime, because nobody there is playing. So it is two moves rather than one. Build the skill, and take it to a floor where people are reaching for it.

Games of Passion — the ones you would play for free.

Now look at the dance machine with the arrows on the floor, or the racing cabinet you climb inside. Feed it, play it, and when it ends you look for the ticket slot and the machine does not have one. Those machines pay no tickets at all, and people queue for them anyway.

That is the mechanic, and it is easy to walk past. Every other machine hands you tickets to carry to the counter and trade for a prize, and this chapter has already said what the good prize does: it converts back into tokens. A Game of Passion skips the counter entirely. Its prize arrives while you are playing, which makes it the only machine on the floor that refills the tank it runs on.

Allyship has that machine. Somewhere in what you already do there is a part you would keep at with no tickets in it at all. It has chance and skill

inside it, as every Game of Passion does, but the payout is not why you are standing at it. You would come back tomorrow whether or not it ever paid.

Passion earns one because it powers the other two. Chance needs you present for years before the jackpot lands. Skill needs you practicing long past boredom. Neither survives on discipline. Most frameworks call that love a liability, too invested, too irrational. In the Arcade it is the power supply, and it is why you are still holding a book about allyship when quitting was always the easier play.

So take the one you brought with you and sort it, once. Where is it Chance, moving on its own clock, asking only that you stay in the game? Where is it Skill, waiting for you to get better, and to carry that better to people who want it? Where is it Passion, the part you would keep playing after every reasonable person told you to stop? You do not need a clean answer. You just put your hands on the joystick.

THE SIX FACES

You just sorted your situation into three kinds of game. Now meet the six who can teach you to play it.

Six Game Masters run the Infinite Arcade, and each one has spent a lifetime on a different kind of allyship game. The **Shaman** feels what is happening before anyone can name it. The **Challenger** moves when everyone else freezes. The **Regent** keeps what works and hands it on. The **Architect** makes the right move the easy move. The **Diplomat** keeps people at the table who should have walked out an hour ago. The **Sage** sees which game is actually being played. Each of them plays all three games you just met: a jackpot they chase, a signature skill, a reason they keep coming back.

You walked in already knowing how to play one of these games.

You have a home face, one you reach for without deciding to, one that feels like plain decency rather than a strategy. *That “without deciding” is your unconscious game master, still calling the moves.* You are good at this face. You have spent years sharpening it. You have also played it so hard, so long, that you have started to run its shadow.

The shadow lives in the face you overplay. Every face has one: its own strength pushed past the point where it still helps. The Diplomat keeps everyone at the table until nothing can be decided. The Challenger draws a clean line straight through the people he meant to protect. The Architect falls for the blueprint and never shows up in person. (If the first half of this chapter felt like it was reading your mail, that is one face's shadow, the Diplomat's, worn so long it stopped looking like a choice. I know that shadow from the inside: I kept this very book in conversation for three years, everyone comfortable, nothing decided. If the Diplomat is your home face, you already know. If a different one is, you know it by its own shadow.)

You do care too much, and it costs you. You care about everyone (you would say so, and mean it), and you run all of that care through one face, on a field too narrow to hold it. It burns you down, because one face cannot carry that much. It misses, because one face is the wrong move as often as the right one.

Sometimes the friend, the coworker, the kid, the community you show up for needs a Challenger (one clean, costly line), and all you have is the Diplomat, so you keep the peace and they never get what they came for. Sometimes they need an Architect to change the rule that keeps hurting them, and you give them the Shaman's feel for what everyone is carrying, and the rule does not move. The reason to widen your range is the person in front of you, the one who needed a move you did not have.

One form runs through every Face: the Five-Move Form. You learn it with the Shaman in Chapter 3. Every school after uses the same form, then teaches its own changes: what that Face asks you to notice, open to, clean up, grow through, and show in the world.

You can feel which face is your home. Hold onto it. In the next section you put it on paper.

BUILD YOUR ALLYSHIP CHARACTER

Every roleplaying game hands you a sheet before it hands you a story. You write down who your character is, and from then on the table can hold you to it: what you are good at, what you avoid, what you swore. Nobody changes

into somebody else between sessions without the table seeing it, because the claim sits on paper in front of everyone.

Allyship gets played without one. You can be held to a sentence you wrote. You cannot be held to one you only meant.

Appendix H is the sheet. This is yours, a few lines filled in for who you are right now, and every chapter after this one adds another.

Your home face. The one you already play, the one you just recognized as yours. Write it down.

Your shadow. Your home face has a bad night. Tired, scared, or spent, it stops being your strength and turns into the move you overplay: the Diplomat who keeps the peace until nothing gets decided, the Challenger who scorches the people he came to protect. You catch this one by feel: under strain it comes in heavier, tighter, more reactive than your real move. Write down the version of your face you fall into on empty. Treat it as your tell rather than your enemy.

Your myth. Back at the start you met the ten versions of *allyship means being good*. Write down the one that runs you hardest, the rule you have been playing by without ever agreeing to it. (The Myths Read sorts your real top few, unflattering and exact, and turns each one into a first move.)

Your quest. Not “get better at allyship.” A cause. The specific fight, community, or person you are actually in this for. Name them. This is who your range is for.

That is the sheet for now. It fills in as you play: a superpower you will only spot in motion, an autopilot pattern you will catch yourself running, a line added in every chapter ahead.

Pen and paper hold this. Date every version, and across a year of play you can watch your face, your shadow, and your myths move, which is the change you cannot see from inside a single week.

THE READER’S OATH

What follows is a bit of theater. Do it anyway. Every serious game keeps an oath (the scout’s, the athlete’s, the doctor’s), and you say the words out loud

to drive them past your thinking mind, into the place where you actually make your moves.

So say it. Out loud if you can, because a sentence said out loud is harder to take back.

I am playing this game. I am not the game.

I take the seat, and from here every move is chosen.

I will feel what rises and burn it clean, and never again spend myself as the fuel.

I will reach for the move they need, not only the one I know how to make.

I will guard the conditions that keep us both players.

I will fall short, and I will not call falling short a reason to leave.

I am not here to be good. I am here to keep playing.

This oath is not to me. You can't fail me: you can only fail yourself.

The only way to lose is to stop playing.

CAPTURE WHAT LANDS — THE BAR DECK

I wrote this chapter to challenge you, because writing this book is my allyship practice and you are the person I am making my move on.

What happens next keeps happening to me. A sentence in somebody else's book lands hard enough that I stop reading. By morning the charge is gone and I am the same person who opened the book. Moved, and unchanged.

Writing the charge down is supposed to stop that fade. I have filled notebooks. Years of them. I can count on one hand the times I have gone back to read one. Getting a thought out of your head and onto a page is halfway to something, and then everything breaks in what happens next. Nobody has ever sold a notebook on how good it feels to reread it, and rereading one is a job. The charge goes in. It does not come back out.

Years ago I started carrying blank poker cards instead. When something landed hard, I wrote it on a card and the card came with me. The surprise was where the memory went. Even when I could not remember what a card said, I remembered where it lived, third from the back, the one with the bent corner. A notebook stores a sentence you have to go find. A deck stores a place you already know, and the place hands the sentence back.

A **BAR** is that card. Buy a pack of blank pocket-sized ones before the next chapter. The size is the point: a card you can hold on a train is a card you will look at, and a deck you can shuffle is a deck you will reread.

The name is the method. **Breakthrough**: what hit you. **Action**: the one move it points to. **Reflection**: what changed when you moved. The first is what you write while the charge is live; the other two after you have spent it on a move.

Every BAR becomes a card in a deck that is yours, built from what actually hit you instead of someone else's checklist. Read, capture, move, and by the last chapter you hold a deck no one else could have built. Stuck in a live moment a year from now, you draw from it and it hands you back something you earned once already. That is what the notebook on the shelf never did: it kept the moment that changed you where you could pick it up and play it again.

YOUR FIRST BAR

Before you go in, make your first BAR.

Something in this chapter hit you, or something from the last few days still sits with you. Find it and write it down. One or two sentences, in whatever words are already in your head. You are not solving it or explaining it. You are catching it before it fades, the way I caught mine on those poker cards.

Then keep it on you. That card is the first in your deck, and it stays in reach for the rest of the book.

That is the whole move. You wrote down something that impacted you, and you kept it somewhere you will actually find it again. Reading gave you the hit. This is you keeping it.

Make the move.

Enter the Forest.

. . .

Playing along

Find the hundred-and-twenty-card deck, for when you want the moves in your hands, at **masteringlyship.com**.